

Walker McDuffie, RHP, North Carolina

2026 Stats: 3.63 ERA/72 IP/1.375 WHIP/89 K/43 BB

5-11, 180

Metrics

FB: 92.6/15.5 IVB/10.7 HB/-4.13 VAA/5.6 ext/5.3 relH/32.9% zone/23.4 AA/6.6% usage/2210 rpm

SI: 92.5/10.8 IVB/15.7 HB/-5.67 VAA/34% zone/22.2 AA/35.8% usage/2220 rpm

SWP: 82.5/-2.1 IVB/-11.9 HB/-7.35 VAA/29% zone/15.5 AA/42.5% usage/2740 rpm

CH: 86.3/1.5 IVB/18.9 HB/-6.85 VAA/13.1% zone/19.4 AA/15.1% usage/1900 rpm

Write-up

Walker McDuffie took a step backward statistically in 2026 after being the fireman for a 2025 Super Regional hosting UNC squad, relinquishing his late-inning fireman role while transitioning into a larger workload. Standing just 5-foot-11, he wins differently than most professional prospects, relying on deception, above-average feel for manipulating movement, and one of the better sweepers in the ACC rather than overwhelming velocity. His arsenal revolves around a heavy sinker/sweeper combination that consistently disrupts right-handed hitters while flashing an intriguing changeup that gives him a viable third offering against lefties. The four-seam fastball has largely become a show-me pitch, making the profile heavily east-west and forcing the sinker to shoulder much of the workload. Long-term, the path to remaining a starter hinges on increasing trust in the changeup or developing another pitch capable of changing eye levels. Even if that never materializes, the sinker/sweeper pairing provides a strong floor as a high-leverage bullpen arm capable of generating both ground balls and swing-and-miss.

The four-seam fastball has become largely obsolete within McDuffie's arsenal, accounting for less than seven percent of his pitches during 2026. The pitch possesses average ride with modest arm-side movement but lacks the velocity or life necessary to consistently beat hitters above the zone. The low arm slot creates some carry, but without significant usage, it really doesn't function as a weapon. He primarily used it to steal an occasional strike or change the hitter's visual before returning to the

sinker-heavy attack. While the pitch flashed enough carry to generate an occasional elevated whiff, it currently serves little purpose within the overall profile. Unless the shape changes or usage increases significantly, it projects as nothing more than a show-me fastball. 30/35 pitch

The sinker is the foundation of McDuffie's fastball attack and complements the sweeper exceptionally well. Sitting in the low-90s with above-average arm-side run and often getting to enough depth to generate uncomfortable angles, the pitch consistently attacked the lower half of the zone while producing soft contact and ground balls. McDuffie showed confidence throwing it to both sides of the plate, allowing the late run to carry it off barrels against lefties and into the hands of right-handed hitters. The command is generally solid despite a modest zone rate, with most misses occurring just off the plate rather than leaking back into damage areas. While the raw movement is not elite, the combination of angle, deception, and sequencing allows the sinker to comfortably project as an above-average complementary fastball. 45/50 pitch

The sweeper is the clear carrying tool of the arsenal and one of the better breaking balls in the ACC. Thrown with elite spin approaching 2,750 rpm, it features true sweep with enough depth to consistently miss barrels while maintaining excellent shape through the entirety of the outing. McDuffie leaned heavily on the pitch against right-handed hitters, generating 66 whiffs while posting a 42% whiff rate and over a 30% put-away rate. He demonstrated advanced command of the pitch, repeatedly locating it beneath the zone and off the outer edge where hitters were forced to chase. The consistency of both the shape and execution already allows it to function as a legitimate professional out pitch, and it comfortably projects as the premier weapon within the profile. 55/60 pitch

The changeup quietly emerged as one of the more intriguing pitches in McDuffie's arsenal despite being used almost exclusively against left-handed hitters. The pitch features heavy fade with quality velocity separation and enough late tumble to consistently disappear beneath barrels. More importantly, McDuffie demonstrated above-average feel for locating it down and arm-side, producing an outstanding combination of chase and swing-and-miss despite the limited usage. The decision to almost completely shelve the pitch against right-handed hitters limits its present value, but the underlying traits suggest considerably more upside than the usage indicates. Expanding the changeup

beyond a strict platoon weapon would significantly improve his chances of remaining in a professional rotation and would help prevent left-handed hitters from sitting exclusively on the sinker. 45/55+ pitch